CHAPTER SIXTEEN

France, Antisemitism, and the Prognosis for European Jewry

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The prognosis for European Jewry is bleak. In 2013, in my essay, "You Only Live Twice," which appeared in the American online journal *Mosaic*, I contended that European Jews both underwent a remarkable rebirth and revival in the post-Holocaust era, and are currently facing renewed existential threats that may force many of them to emigrate to Israel or other places.[1] I was not off the mark. Antisemitism is indeed increasing, either in terms of actual violence against Jews—think of the massacres in Brussels, in May 2014, and in Paris in January 2015—or in the level of anti-Jewish or anti-Israel discourse.

How is it that the fortunes of European Jews has changed so dramatically and so quickly for the worse? Much can be learned from two events that took place in France, where about one-half of European Jewry is concentrated, in January 2014. First, the Dieudonné-Valls confrontation, and how French public opinion reacted to it. Dieudonné M'bala M'bala is an African-French former commedian who has turned his shows over the years into rabid anti-Zionist and anti-Jewish gatherings. More recently, he created and launched the "quenelle," an inverted Hitlerian salute (one arm down, the other one touching the shoulder) as an expression of contempt for Jews and everything related to the Holocaust. The gesture is enjoying growing popularity in France and other countries. Among some sectors of the youth, it is seen as the cool thing to do in front of Jewish buildings or Holocaust memorials like the one for Drancy in the suburbs of Paris or the Mahnmal in Berlin. A dozen young, anonymous, European-looking passers-by were photographed performing the quenelle under the Rue des Juifs street sign in Strasbourg. In England, Nicolas Anelka, a French football star of African descent playing for the West Bromwich Albion Football Club, indulged in the quenelle salute on December 28, 2013, after scoring against West Ham, and declined to apologize. Immigrant players from Manchester City's and Liverpool Football Clubs were also reported to have performed the gesture.

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